


Japanese giant salamander

This is one of the biggest amphibians—up to 4½ ft (1.4 m) long. It lives in cold mountain streams and gets almost all its oxygen directly through its wrinkled skin.


Amphiuma

Only found in North America, this aquatic salamander, with its tiny limbs and eel-like body, has both gills and lungs, but the gills are hidden under flaps of skin.


Mushroom-tongued salamander

This tiny salamander is one of nearly 500 species from the Central American tropics that lack lungs and breathe only through their skin.


Fire salamander

This air-breathing salamander from European forests is unusual in giving birth to live young—as aquatic larvae—rather than laying eggs.


Great crested newt

Newts are land salamanders that return to water to breed, changing their appearance by developing smoother skin and tail fins.

Mudpuppy

Salamanders are amphibians shaped like lizards, with long tails and short legs. The mudpuppy is a salamander that lives on river- and lake beds in North America. They get their unusual name because it was once thought they barked like a dog, but in fact their sound is more like a squeak.

Lake living

The common mudpuppy is one of eight species of mudpuppies found in the wettest parts of the United States and Canada—mainly in the Great Lakes and the rivers that flow from them. It lurks among the mud and silt, hiding during the day and emerging at night to feed.

Swamp dweller

In the warm, wet swamps of southern Louisiana, many mudpuppies are yellower than elsewhere in the US and youngsters often venture out of water into woodland leaf litter.

Organs for breathing

During their life cycle, most amphibians go through a big change called metamorphosis, where their aquatic larva turns into an air-breathing adult. But in some salamanders, such as the mudpuppy, this process is incomplete. The adults keep their gills, allowing them to continue breathing underwater.

